industrial cylinders after due purging. The team was also was directed to make efforts to import tankers, for a bridge-gap arrangement.[24]

In the same virtual meeting, the prime minister was surprised to see two senior officials of the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) present: Mr Guruprasad Mohapatra, Secretary of DPIIT and Ms Sumita Dawra, Additional Secretary of DPIIT. Only last week, they had both tested positive for COVID-19. Both officers had been frontrunners in ensuring scaling up of oxygen and ensuring timely distribution throughout the country. Due to the fact that they had to be physically present at work during a pandemic, DPIIT had arranged for regular testing of their officials. In the first week of April both had tested negative, but on 12 April, Ms Dawra had tested positive following which on 15 April, Mr Mohapatra also tested positive for COVID-19. However, further blood work and investigations revealed that Mr Mohapatra was already in the second week of the disease—the infection had evaded the earlier tests and he had gotten false negatives up until this advanced point of the infection. Mr Mohapatra had gotten considerably weak by the 16 April meeting with the prime minister, so much so that during the meeting, he sat cross-legged on the bed. At one point during the meeting, he tried to reach out to a copper water bottle kept at the side of the room and he had to struggle to get up and make his way to the bottle. Watching his condition, the prime minister asked, ‘Guruprasadji, why are you in the meeting? I am surprised to see you; I know that you have tested positive. You must take time off and tend to your health.’ Mr Mohapatra gestured to show his appreciation for the prime minister’s concern and tried to say something, but his mic had an audio issue and what he said wasn’t very audible. The next day, on 18 April, he was admitted to AIIMS, his condition worsening over the next month and unfortunately, on 19 June, he lost his life to the virus.[25] It is truly relentless service from bravehearts like Mr Mohapatra, who succumbed to the enemy while fighting for the rest of us which encapsulates the true spirit of India’s fight against COVID-19.

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15 APRIL 2021

INDIA | 15,68,138 ACTIVE CASES | 1,755,624 DEATHS | 10.23 CRORE VACCINE DOSES